The Emptying — Phase 1 Concept (Colony Sim)

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This replaces the earlier RTS and colony concept. The earlier Phase 1, 2 and 3 docs remain as a record; much of the Phase 3 detail carries over (see the last section).

Pitch and identity

You are a relic in a keep, quietly ruling a kingdom through the monarchs you influence, and a whole society grows around you on rules, incentives and nudges rather than orders.

- **Genre:** sandbox colony sim. No RTS layer and no player avatar.
- **Core rule:** you never directly control people. They act on your laws, your rules, the incentives you set and their own personalities. You hang the carrot; they follow.
- **Length:** indefinite.
- **Mode:** single player.
- **Production:** William plus Claude (programming), Synty art. Engine not chosen. No deadline.

Reference	What it brings
Songs of Syx	Large-scale settlement building
RimWorld	Colonist depth, raids, a living storyteller
Oxygen Not Included	Permission boxes instead of direct orders; a small random starting crew
Tropico	A visible ruler; steering a population with policy
Dwarf Fortress	A random world populated around you each game

You are the relic

The player is the relic at the heart of the keep: the king or queen believes they rule, but every law comes from you, and how far people obey depends on what they believe and how strong you've grown.

The ruler

- A king or queen lives in the world, Tropico-style, fully under the relic's power.
- When a ruler dies, the relic picks the successor from 3 candidates in a popup.

Laws and obedience

- You can set any law. That doesn't mean people will follow it.
- Play good, bad or in between, as in the real world.
- **Influence** is abstract: as the relic's power grows, people become more willing to follow rules they normally wouldn't.
- **Campaigns** shift public opinion before a law. Example: people oppose cults, so you run a campaign that softens their views, then pass a rule allowing cult buildings, and they're more open to it. The same works for letting vampires join.
- Think of how a government shapes a population, destabilizes rivals or builds support for a war: soft power, not orders.

The world

The terrain is randomly generated each game, 7 Days to Die-style, and hand-made points of interest are placed on it at random; groups spawn once you place your keep (changed October 26 from a fixed, hand-crafted map).

The map and your keep

- One large map with randomly generated terrain (height, biomes, rivers and lakes) forming regions, big enough to want extra settlements such as a mining town. Every building, ruin and other point of interest is designed by hand; where each one goes is random.
- You can place your keep anywhere, and the spot matters. Example: near a magic forest you get more wild animal attacks and more creature immigrants.
- Once the keep is placed, the other groups spawn as 1 to 3 people with goals, and they grow as you do.

Groups on the map

- Small groups such as cults rather than giant factions. They grow into small settlements, never huge ones.

- Attacks happen on the map and you see them coming, RimWorld-style.

The relic's ring

- The relic projects a ring of influence around the keep.
- Fragments you find or create let you found settlements farther away.
- Laws are set only at home and apply everywhere, so where you build matters. People settled near a dangerous cult want protection, and may leave without it.
- People can live outside the ring, but most won't leave it unless they really have to.

Beyond the map

- Kingdoms exist only on an off-map menu layer. You can trade with them, and they can send attacks.

The people

People build most of the town themselves; the crown builds only government works and steers everything else with incentives.

No direct control

- You can't click a person and move them.
- Like Oxygen Not Included, you tick which kinds of work each person may do (hauling, cleaning, building and so on). All adults can do the basics, according to skill.

Who builds what

The crown builds	Colonists build
Walls, towers, gates, defenses	Their own homes
Government housing	Shops and businesses
Prison, hospital, research halls	Production buildings (woodcutter, smithy, mill)
Warehouses, roads	Farms on their land
The keep and its rooms	Temples, built by faith groups

- Example: you zone an area for homes; people see they need wood and build a woodcutter's shack. Each building has a worker limit you can adjust, and the best people take the roles.
- Early on everyone pitches in. The first settlers become landowners as the town grows.

Steering

Like a real government, you get people to act without telling them what to do.

- Zones: residential, commercial, industrial, farm.
- Grants and tax breaks for building types you want.
- Crown requests with rewards attached.
- Wages on government buildings to attract workers, such as tower guards.

Lords

- Lords exist but are self-contained: they emerge and grow as your kingdom does. You can also force one to be made.
- Missions run through the off-map menu. Without a lord, regular people can go, with lower returns and a higher chance of injury.

Defense

- Attacks are visible on the map. You sound an alarm, and able fighters gather at muster flags you place, then fight according to military policies and their personalities.
- Towers need people inside; government pay attracts them.

Races and unlocks

You start as humans, the most balanced race, and unlock others for future games by meeting and allying with them.

- An unlocks screen on the main menu shows the races you've earned. There will be a good number.
- Every start begins with 3 random people of the chosen race, as in Oxygen Not Included.
- Every race has environmental needs and weaknesses. Humans can do it all.
- **Example, vampires:** much better starts near ruins, which offer a ready home and cover from the sun. They must capture humans or stay inactive during the day.

Story, threat and length

The game is set before the earlier story: the being is still asleep, but its influence is already in the world, and it grows as you gather relics.

- Relics exist and give real power. As you research them, the being's influence grows and the danger rises with it: stranger events, spreading cults, nightmares.
- Play is indefinite; there's no forced ending.
- **Losing:** the game is over if your main settlement falls.

Carrying over and open questions

Most of the earlier Phase 3 design fits this direction and will be reviewed in Phase 2; the RTS layer, the hero and the fixed story are gone.

Likely to carry over (to confirm in Phase 2)

- Colonist simulation: needs, moods, preferences, relationships, morality, blocs, race reproduction, aging
- Laws, crime and justice, now with obedience depending on belief and the relic's power
- Economy: wages, zones, private businesses, land taxes, corruption and audits
- Research, religion (7 faiths), captives and slavery
- Combat rules: damage, armor, after-battle survival math, trauma
- Game data, saves, UI (with the advisor), audio

Dropped

- The hero, RTS battles and their economy, claimed keeps as separate maps
- The fixed story: the funeral, the midpoint sacrifice, the final war and the Emptying as an ending

Open questions

- [x] ~~**Campaigns:** target one belief and run 10 to 30 days. They cost gold and need a speaker (a lord, a priest or a town crier at a government building). Opinion shifts a little each day, faster with a skilled speaker; people with strong views resist; a blunt campaign can backfire and harden opposition.~~

- [x] ~~**Fragments:** found at sites on the map, made by feeding the relic something costly, or traded for. Each creates a smaller ring of its own where a new settlement can grow.~~
- [x] ~~**Off-map kingdoms:** random each game. The design sets the possible variables, and kingdoms, their people and their religions are rolled from them.~~
- [x] ~~**The being's escalation:** four stages driven by relics researched and influence. Power and danger rise together, so a player can stay small and safe or chase relics and risk it.~~
- [x] ~~**Tutorial and difficulty:** a dedicated small tutorial. Easy, normal and hard are preset bundles of settings, and players can tweak every setting themselves.~~
- [ ] Ironman: available as an option

Stage	What happens
Quiet	Rare odd events, uneasy animals
Stirring	Nightmares, small cults forming, strange immigrants
Restless	Cult uprisings, possessions, creatures drawn to the relic
Waking	Major events that can threaten the kingdom itself